Strength-Based Regional Asset Mapping Protocol

Act 170 Merger Committees

Purpose

Build a shared understanding of the strengths that already exist across the region, and identify opportunities that should inform the committee's evaluation of governance options, including a potential unified union school district.

How to Use This Protocol

This protocol is written for facilitators to lead and for committee members. Each step includes the questions members will work through. Members are encouraged to review the protocol before the meeting.

Intentions for this session:

- Name strengths across the region, not only in your own district.
- Identify assets. Do not rank or compare communities.
- Record questions that need more information. Do not try to resolve them today.

Agenda at a Glance (75 minutes)

Step	Focus	Time
Introduction	Why we are doing this	5 min
Step 1	Identify regional strengths	15 min
Step 2	Build the regional asset map	25 min
Step 3	Explore regional opportunities	20 min
Step 4	Record findings and next steps	10 min

Introduction: Why We Are Doing This (5 minutes)

Act 170 directs facilitators to support merger committees with strength-based asset mapping (Section 13(a)). It also requires committees to analyze the strengths and challenges of existing district structures and explain how their recommendations address educational opportunity, operational efficiency, transparency, accountability, and cost (Section 13(b)(4)(D)).

Before weighing any governance configuration, the committee needs a clear picture of what already exists across its schools and communities and what is working well.

This session addresses three questions:

1. What do we have? The strengths and resources that currently benefit students.

2. What could we build on? How those strengths might be preserved, shared, or expanded.
3. What does this mean for our work? The opportunities and considerations that should inform the committee's analysis.

Asset mapping is an early step. It does not presume an outcome and does not replace the further analysis Act 170 requires.

Step 1. Identify Regional Strengths (15 minutes)

For members: Identify two or three important strengths in your district or community that benefit students. Use the categories below to think broadly.

Asset Area	**Strengths to Consider**
Educational opportunities	Academic programs, CTE, arts, enrichment, extracurriculars, effective instructional practices
Student services and supports	Special education, counseling, intervention programs, other student supports
People and expertise	Educators, specialized staff, school leaders, professional expertise
Facilities and resources	Buildings, technology, transportation, financial resources, operational systems
Community connections	Partnerships, traditions, local identity, community involvement, student belonging
Governance and organization	Leadership, governance practices, collaboration, administrative capacity

Step 2. Build the Regional Asset Map (25 minutes)

For members: Using the strengths from Step 1, build a shared asset map/chart. For each asset, note where it exists, how it benefits students, and whether it suggests an opportunity for the broader region.

Strength or Asset	**Where It Exists**	**How It Benefits Students**	**Potential Regional Opportunity**
Example: Strong CTE partnerships	District A	Provides career pathways	Explore broader student access
Example: Effective literacy practices	District B	Supports early reading success	Share instructional expertise

Strength or Asset	Where It Exists	How It Benefits Students	Potential Regional Opportunity

Step 3. Explore Regional Opportunities (20 minutes)

For members: Review the completed asset map and discuss the questions below. Consider both potential benefits and the importance of protecting what already works.

1. What should we preserve? Which strengths matter most to students, families, and communities?
2. What could we share or expand? Where might regional coordination improve opportunities, access, services, or use of resources?
3. What differences or gaps deserve further study? Where are opportunities or resources unevenly available, and what information would help us understand why?
4. How might governance structure affect these strengths? Which structures could preserve strengths, expand opportunities, or address challenges? What could be at risk under a change, and what could be at risk if nothing changes?

Step 4. Record Findings and Next Steps (10 minutes)

For members: Close by naming the most important observations from the discussion.

Finding	Committee Observations
Strengths to preserve	
Opportunities to share or expand	
Differences or gaps requiring further study	
Areas of differing perspective	
Information needed for future analysis	
Implications for evaluating governance options	

What Happens Next

These findings become part of the committee's working record. They will inform later analysis of current district strengths and challenges, regional opportunities, and potential governance configurations. The committee will revisit the asset map as new information becomes available.